

He moved. The husband reappeared in the photograph. Their guide spoke of Edward James, Plutarco Gastélum, and the carpenters, masons, and gardeners whose work had made the place. Q looked from a concrete flower to the stair beside it.

“It looks as though a building kept changing its mind.”

Chano looked up. “Expensive habit.”

Q asked how many people had worked on the construction. The guide said more than a hundred and fifty. Chano asked about the carpenters, then how the shapes had been made. By the next stop he was walking beside the guide. Lucía caught Q looking pleased.

“You can ask another question. He hasn't hired him.”

“That bit looks unfinished,” Chano said.

“Which bit?” Lucía asked.

He considered the surroundings. “A fair objection.”

Q wanted to climb farther. His knee produced a warning on the next rise. He asked the guide whether the higher part involved more climbing. It did, and the descent would not excuse him from using the same knee.

“Then I'd better stay here. Will you show me what I miss?” he asked Lucía.

“Of course.”

He stopped at the permitted resting place while the others continued with the guide.

For a while he was irritated. Then he noticed water collecting on the underside of a leaf until its own weight made it fall. He held a finger beneath the next one. It struck the metal and ran toward his wrist. He changed the angle of his hand and waited.

When Chano came back, Q asked whether he had missed anything wonderful.

“Yes.”

“You could soften that.”

“There were more stairs.”



*The Next Drop*

“My work can be reviewed. So can the institutions using it. You would need to examine both.”

An advertisement interrupted him to explain that Castalia had built accountability into its future. Q laughed, then wished he could know whether Prime had seen the cut before it was broadcast.

Petra looked from the television to Q.

“Is that family?”

“Something like it.”

“Does he also need a socket?”

“Yes.”

“Tell him to ask before putting the bed in front of one. Your friend has already done it.”

At supper, a truck driver wanted to know whether Q was dangerous. Q said his body was heavy enough to require care, and that he was currently trying to pass a plate without hitting a glass.

The driver moved the glass.

“You're doing all right.”

They talked about the road and a clutch repair that had cost the driver two days.

“My brother-in-law said to mention his name.”

“Did it help?” Q asked.

“The mechanic knew exactly who to blame for my expectations.”

“Is the clutch working now?”

“Beautifully. That's the annoying part. I'll have to go back to him.”

“Without mentioning your brother-in-law?”

“I'm going to mention him somewhere more useful. He wants me to help him move on Sunday.”

Petra put down the tortillas.

“Tell him to allow two days.”

A woman recognized Lucía from the old video and asked whether she had married the machine.

“No,” Lucía said.

“But in the video - ”

“The video was wrong about a number of things,” Q said. “We



Allow Two Days



whether Q worked there. He said he was a guest helping Petra. The field on the form offered owner, employee, contractor, or other. The inspector selected other and asked where the table was going.

Chano looked disappointed.

“You expected equipment?” Q asked.

“I had something ready.”

“Save it for the next hotel.”

The inspection found staining that needed checking above the visible patch. Petra kept the room closed pending repair and asked which work the notice actually required. She refused a recommended contractor until she had compared the quote. The inspector clarified that she could use another qualified contractor. She wrote that on her copy because the recommendation had sounded compulsory.

The missing room had once been occupied by a wedding party. Petra told the story while waiting for the roofer to call.

The bride wanted one quiet night, the groom wanted everyone to be happy, and the groom's mother wanted a separate room for the cake. The cake obtained its wish first.

A mistake on one of the civil documents had supplied the relatives with a reason to continue arguments they had brought from home. By midnight they had moved twice, occupied the kitchen, and borrowed a bucket for ice. In the morning the bride and groom left together without settling what the mother considered settled by paying for the cake.

“Did the marriage last?” Q asked.

“Longer than their promise to return my bucket.”

Petra had told them later that she wanted to tell the story to guests. They agreed to changed names and disagreed about which detail was funny. The mother said the cake room had been sensible. Petra kept that reply in the story because it was.



*A Room for the Cake*

Her guest records were kept behind the desk. She laid brown paper over an older page and held it down with the stapler while she checked the room numbers with Q.

"I can read you the numbers," she said.

"That will do."

They labeled the keys. Q made the figure seven too elaborate and Petra asked whether it was expecting to inherit money. He redid it plainly.

The roofer called. He could inspect that afternoon. Petra put the time in her repair notebook beside the failed promise from yesterday, then asked him which part she should buy for the sign. He needed to see it.

"Everyone needs to see everything," she said after hanging up.

"He may be right about the sign," Q said.

"I know. I'm complaining anyway."

The power had returned during the night. Q had recharged and checked the journey reserve before coming downstairs. His adviser confirmed their meeting; the repair question was still unanswered. Q saved it at the top of tomorrow's notes, then corrected tomorrow to today.

Before leaving, Q asked whether she wanted a copy of the key list. She did. He gave her the sheet and kept no guest names because none had been needed.

Petra sent them away with oranges. Chano paid the remaining room balance. Q had paid his share the night before. Petra counted the change into Chano's hand while he tried to keep the oranges in the bag.

From the bus, Q watched the sign lose its letters one by one behind a bend. The final O was still dark. Petra expected someone to look at it that afternoon. Q hoped he came.



*The Heir to Seven*